ADVANCED PLACEMENT · U.S. HISTORY

CLASS 25 · AP PERIOD 5

ERA 9

A House Dividing

1850 – 1856

The Compromise of 1850 · Kansas-Nebraska · Bleeding Kansas

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did efforts to compromise over slavery instead push the nation toward civil war?

KEY TERMS

Compromise of 1850 · Fugitive Slave Act · Uncle Tom's Cabin · Kansas-Nebraska Act · Bleeding Kansas

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 5.4–5.5 · AMSCO Ch. 5.4–5.5

SECTION

A House Dividing

The Problem of Slavery in the West

LAND

The Mexican Cession

New territory reopens the question: slave or free?

→

BLOCKED

Wilmot Proviso Fails

The South kills any outright ban on slavery.

→

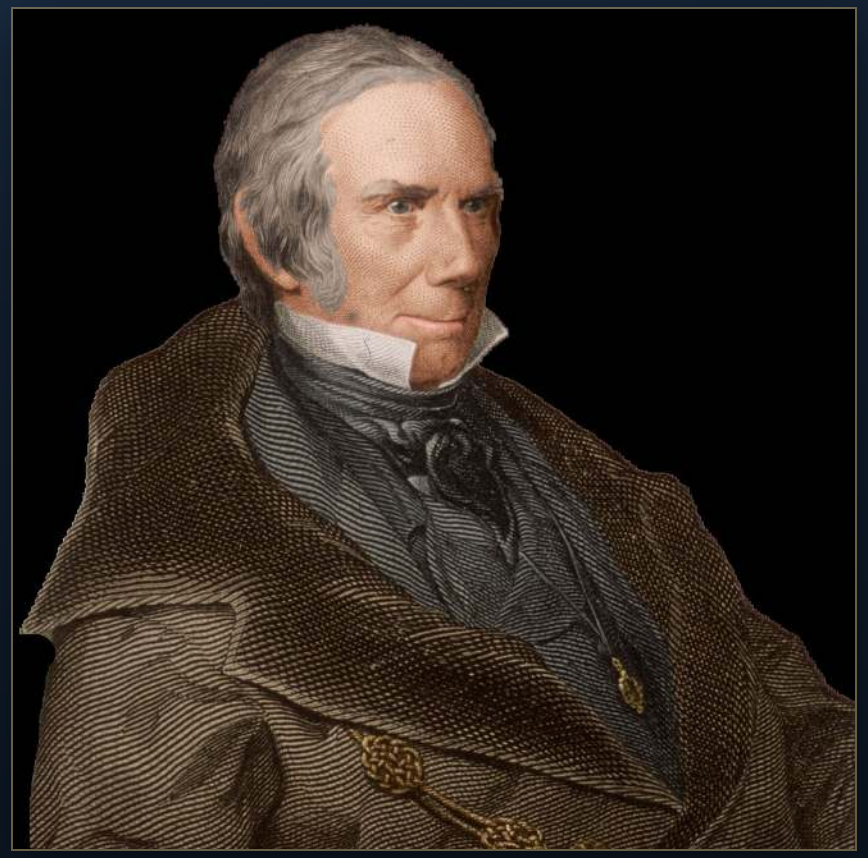
'SOLUTION'

Popular Sovereignty

Let each territory's settlers vote on slavery.

The Great Compromiser

- **Henry Clay**, now over 70, crafted one last grand bargain.
- His goal: satisfy North and South enough to save the Union.
- The **Compromise of 1850** passed after seven months of debate.



The Compromise of 1850

A fragile peace that satisfied no one for long

PROVISION	WHAT IT DID
California	Admitted as a free state
Fugitive Slave Act	Forced Northerners to help capture escapees
Utah & New Mexico	Slavery decided by **popular sovereignty**
Washington, D.C.	Ended the slave trade (but not slavery)

SECTION

The North Recoils

The Fugitive Slave Act



- The **Fugitive Slave Act** forced Northerners to return escapees.
- Even free Black Northerners risked being seized and enslaved.
- It made slavery a Northern problem—and radicalized many.

Uncle Tom's Cabin, 1852

- **Harriet Beecher Stowe**'s novel dramatized slavery's cruelty.
- It sold over 300,000 copies in a year.
- It turned countless Northerners against slavery.



The Underground Railroad



- Secret networks helped enslaved people escape north to freedom.
- Conductors like **Harriet Tubman** risked everything.
- Nearly 100,000 escaped before the Civil War.

SECTION

Bleeding Kansas

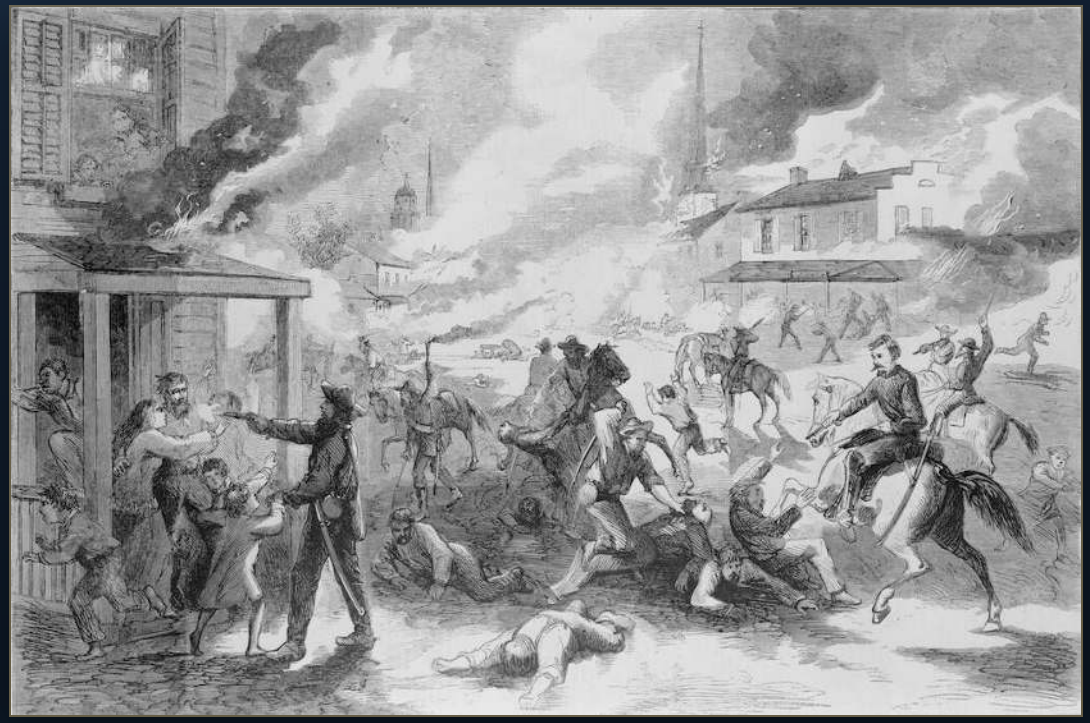
The Kansas-Nebraska Act, 1854



- Senator **Stephen Douglas** opened Kansas and Nebraska to slavery.
- It let settlers decide by **popular sovereignty**.
- This **repealed the Missouri Compromise** line—outraging the North.

'Bleeding Kansas'

- Pro- and anti-slavery settlers flooded into Kansas to sway the vote.
- Violence erupted—including **John Brown**'s deadly raids.
- The territory became a bloody preview of civil war.



Violence in the Senate



- The bloodshed reached Congress itself.
- In 1856, Rep. **Preston Brooks** caned Sen. **Charles Sumner** at his desk.
- It took Sumner three years to recover—and stunned the nation.

A New Party Rises

I

Old Parties Shatter

The Whig Party collapses over slavery and immigration.

II

The Republicans

A new **Republican Party** forms to stop slavery's spread.

III

A Sectional Split

For the first time, a major party is purely Northern.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

A House Dividing

1. The **Compromise of 1850** bought time—but the **Fugitive Slave Act** and **Uncle Tom's Cabin** hardened Northern opinion.
2. The **Kansas-Nebraska Act** repealed the **Missouri Compromise** and ignited **'Bleeding Kansas.'**
3. Violence and the collapse of the old parties gave rise to the **Republican Party**—and pushed the nation toward war.

DISCUSS & APPLY

A House Dividing

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the **Kansas-Nebraska Act** reopened the slavery question and led to violence.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did each attempt at **compromise** end up deepening—not healing—the sectional divide?

ARGUMENTATION

Which did more to inflame the North: the **Fugitive Slave Act** or **Uncle Tom's Cabin**? Defend your claim.

Up next — **Class 26: The Road to Secession** (Dred Scott, John Brown & the Election of 1860)